Inderfurth's advocacy on the Taliban, in 1999, occurred in the context of structural shifts in South Asia's power balance. In May 1998, both India and Pakistan had tested their nuclear arsenal inviting condemnation and sanctions from the international community. Washington was particularly shocked at its failure to intercept the Indian tests and its inability to deter Pakistan from conducting retaliatory tests. Overt nuclearisation of the subcontinent had grave security implications. If the probability of a full-scale conventional war between India and Pakistan went down, the probability of asymmetric warfare under the nuclear umbrella went up. Nuclear weapons gave Pakistan, the relatively weaker of the two states, strategic parity with India. This situation was aggravated by the Kargil conflict between May and July 1999, when Pakistani troops entered the Indian-controlled territory in the Kargil sector of Kashmir and held key strategic positions disrupting the Indian army's supply lines. Calculating that India would not respond heavily due to the nuclear factor, Musharraf ordered the operation just weeks after the signing of the Lahore declaration.[68]

New Delhi, however, responded with full military and diplomatic force, leading to an unconditional withdrawal of Pakistani troops.[69] An ally of Pakistan all these years, Washington blamed Islamabad for being the aggressor and sided with India, strengthening the hands of the partisans.[70] The Kargil conflict had strong reverberations in Afghanistan as well. As soon as the conflict started, Brajesh Mishra ordered the release of a large amount of secret funds to the R&AW to up the ante on Pakistan in Afghanistan.[71] With the Baloch and Pakhtun separatist insurgencies in a dormant state, the R&AW was ordered to do whatever it could to bring Pakistan and the Taliban under military pressure in Afghanistan. The US knew it all. Interestingly, however, the US refuses to publicise specific details about the time, quantity, and nature of India's covert armed support to the UF against the Taliban until today. The various declassified CIA dossiers and diplomatic cables that mention India's role in Afghanistan during the 1990s, have dates and specifics about Indian spies blacked out.

The shift in the US perceptions on Afghanistan had generated (misplaced) rumours that Washington was conspiring with New Delhi to oust the Taliban by force. Refuting them strongly, the Clinton administration maintained that it was looking for political alternatives based on negotiations and not military force. In